Introduction to Ethics

PHIL0300

Instructor Info

Travis McKenna

Office Hrs: Mon & Wed 1-2pm

1009 Cathedral of Learning

travis.mckenna@pitt.edu

Course Info

Monday & Wednesday

18.00 – 21.15

253 Cathedral of Learning

Overview

This course will serve as an introduction to the fundamental questions of moral philosophy. We will begin by looking at two of the most historically prominent ethical theories: deontology and consequentialism. Deontologists, roughly speaking, think that there are moral norms or principles which make certain actions right or wrong. On the other hand, consequentialists think that we determine whether an action is right or wrong by looking at the consequences it brings about.

In *Module 1*, we will examine each of these theories in turn, understanding the core claims they make. In *Module 2*, we will think about how these two theories stack up against each other and examine several arguments given by philosophers on both sides in favour of their preferred theory. Finally, in *Module 3* we will think about how these moral theories might guide our thinking in a variety of more applied ethical cases.

Material

There is no required textbook for this course. The reading materials for each session will be provided on Canvas.

Assessment

10%	Participation
20%	Two Reading Outlines (1-2 pages), 10% each
30%	Two Writing Assignments (1-2 pages), 15% each
40%	Two Papers (3 pages), 20% each

Participation

Developing the ability to discuss various positions and claims with your peers is an extremely important part of learning how to engage with ideas in a broadly philosophical fashion. A portion of your grade then will be determined by the way in which you go about developing and demonstrating these kinds of philosophical skills.

A wide variety of things will count as 'participation' for the purpose of your grade, including: asking questions in class, offering answers to questions posed either by me or your fellow students, sharing your thoughts on the readings on the discussion board on Canvas, coming to my office hours to discuss the course material, and so on.

To get the best participation grade possible, you should aim to contribute in one of these ways at least once for each session.

Reading Outlines

These will be short, written presentations of a particular reading assigned through the course. The idea is simply to summarise the structure and main thrust of the paper in a relatively succinct fashion. You don't have to capture every single claim made by the paper, and indeed I encourage you to spend more time focussing on the things in the paper that you thought were interesting or important.

It is totally up to you which readings you decide to write on for these outlines, and they are to be submitted *within a week* of the session for which the reading was assigned. Although you must submit at least two reading outlines, *you may submit more than two if you would like*. In the event you submit more than two, your best two reading outlines will count towards your grade.

Writing Assignments

These writing assignments will be short, focussed pieces of writing relating to issues posed by the reading. For each session, I will post 2-3 prompts for these writing assignments. You will be free to submit these reading outlines for whatever prompt you would like, although you cannot choose more than one prompt from a single session. As with the reading outlines, these should be submitted within a week of their corresponding session, and you should feel free to submit more than two (in which case your best two will count for your grade).

Papers

For each module I will post a series of paper prompts. You must choose two of these and submit a 3-page paper based on them. You must have both of your papers submitted by Friday, the 24th of June since that is officially the last day of the semester, but I encourage you to submit at least one of them earlier than that.

As with the other written assignments, you may submit as many as you would like, in which case your best two will count. After I have graded your paper, you will have the option to revise your paper in response to the feedback I've provided and resubmit your paper. In this event I will grade your paper anew and if the new grade is higher this will replace the original grade assigned. Of course, the earlier in the semester you submit your paper the more time you have to take advantage of this.

Academic Integrity

Students in this course will be expected to comply with the University of Pittsburgh's Policy on Academic Integrity. Any student suspected of violating this obligation for any reason during the semester will be required to participate in the procedural process, initiated at the instructor level, as outlined in the University Guidelines on Academic Integrity.

Disability Services

If you have a disability for which you are or may be requesting an accommodation, be sure to contact me within the first two weeks of the summer session, as well as Disability Resources and Services (DRS), 140 William Pitt Union, (412) 648-7890, drsrecep@pitt.edu, (412) 228-5347 for P3 ASL users. DRS will verify your disability and determine reasonable accommodations for this course.

Class Schedule

Given the compact nature of the summer courses, there will be two pieces of reading assigned for each class. Most of the time, we will aim to spend half of the time on the first, take a small break, and then spend the rest of the time on the second.

MODULE 1: Ethical Theories

15/6	Introduction	Russ Shafer-Landau, *Fundamentals of Ethics*, Introduction
5/18	Kant	Immanuel Kant, *Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals*, Preface, 4:393 – 4:401 Sally Sedgwick, 'Kant's Preface'
5/23	Kant II	Kant, *Groundwork*, Section 1 Kant, *Groundwork*, Section 2
5/25	Consequentialism	Shelly Kagan, *The Limits of Morality*, pp. 1-15 John Stuart Mill, *Utilitarianism*, Chapter 2
5/30	MEMORIAL DAY	NO CLASS
6/01	Rule Consequentialism	Brad Hooker, 'Rule-Consequentialism' John Rawls, 'Two Concepts of Rules'

MODULE 2: Deontology vs. Consequentialism

6/06	Williams and Railton	Bernard Williams, 'A Critique of Utilitarianism' Peter Railton, 'Alienation, Consequentialism and the Demands of Morality'
6/08	The Trolley Problem	Philippa Foot, 'The Problem of Abortion and the Doctrine of the Double Effect' Judith Jarvis-Thompson, 'Killing, Letting Die, and The Trolley Problem'
6/13	Counting the Numbers	Peter Singer, 'Famine, Affluence and Morality' John Taurek, 'Should the Numbers Count?'

MODULE 3: Applied Ethics

6/15	Animal Rights	Tom Reagan, 'The Case for Animal Rights' Elizabeth Anderson, 'Animal Rights and the Values of Nonhuman Life'
6/20	Punishment and Justification	Jean Hampton, 'The Moral Education Theory of Punishment' Robert Nozick, 'Retributive Punishment'
6/22	Feminist Ethics	Cheshire Calhoun, 'Justice, Care, and Gender Bias' Annette Baier, 'The Need for More than Justice'